

was gone. D'Artagnan still continued reading, Athos watched him with a smile. D'Artagnan, surprising one of those smiles over his shoulder, put the bundle in its wrapper.

'I beg your pardon,' said Athos.

'Oh! not at all, my friend,' replied the lieutenant, 'I shall tell you—'

'No, don't tell me anything, I beg you; orders are things so sacred, that to one's brother, one's father, the person charged with such orders should never open his mouth. Thus I, who speak to you, and love you more tenderly than brother, father, or all the world—'

'Except your Raoul?'

'I shall love Raoul still better when he shall be a man, and I shall have seen him develop himself in all the phases of his character and his actions—as I have seen you, my friend.'

'You said, then, that you had an order likewise, and that you would not communicate it to me.'

'Yes, my dear D'Artagnan.'

The Gascon sighed. 'There was a time,' said he, 'when you would have placed that order open upon the table, saying, "D'Artagnan, read this scrawl to Porthos, Aramis, and to me."'

'That is true. Oh! that was the time of youth, confidence, the generous season when the blood commands, when it is warmed by feeling!'

'Well! Athos, will you allow me to tell you?'

'Speak, my friend!'

'That delightful time, that generous season, that ruling by warm blood, were all very fine things, no doubt: but I do not regret them at all. It is absolutely like the period of studies. I have constantly met with fools who would boast of the days of penums, ferules, and crusts of dry bread. It is singular, but I never loved all that; for my part, however active and sober I might be (you know if I was so, Athos), however simple I might appear in my clothes, I would not the less have preferred the braveries and embroideries of Porthos to my little perforated cassock, which gave passage to the wind in winter and the sun in summer. I should always, my friend, mistrust him who would pretend to prefer evil to good. Now, in times past all went wrong with me, and every month found a fresh hole in my cassock and in my skin, a gold crown less in my poor purse, of that execrable time of small beer and see-saw, I regret absolutely

nothing, nothing, nothing save our friendship; for within me I have a heart, and it is a miracle that heart has not been dried up by the wind of poverty which passed through all the holes of my cloak, or pierced by the swords of all shapes which passed through the holes in my poor flesh.'

'Do not regret our friendship,' said Athos, 'that will only die with ourselves. Friendship is composed, above all things, of memories and habits, and if you have just now made a little satire upon mine, because I hesitate to tell you the nature of my mission into France—'

'Who! I?—Oh! heavens! if you knew, my dear friend, how indifferent all the missions of the world will henceforth become to me! And he laid his hand upon the parchment in his vest pocket.'

Athos rose from the table and called the host in order to pay the reckoning. 'Since I have known you, my friend,' said D'Artagnan, 'I have never discharged the reckoning. Porthos often did, Aramis sometimes, and you, you almost always drew out your purse with the dessert. I am now rich, and should like to try if it is heroic to pay.'

'Do so,' said Athos, returning his purse to his pocket.

The two friends then directed their steps towards the port, not, however, without D'Artagnan's frequently turning round to watch the transportation of his dear crowns. Night had just spread her thick veil over the yellow waters of the Thames; they heard those noises of casks and pulleys, the preliminaries of preparing to sail which had so many times made the hearts of the musketeers beat when the dangers of the sea were the least of those they were going to face. This time they were to embark on board a large vessel which awaited them at Gravesend, and Charles II, always delicate in small affairs, had sent one of his yachts, with twelve men of his Scots guard, to do honour to the ambassador he was sending to France. At midnight the yacht had deposited its passengers on board the vessel, and at eight o'clock in the morning, the vessel landed the ambassador and his friend on the wharf at Boulogne. Whilst the comte, with Grimaud, was busy procuring horses to go straight to Paris, D'Artagnan hastened to the hostelry where, according to his orders, his little army was to wait for him. These gentlemen were at breakfast upon oysters, fish, and spiced brandy, when D'Artagnan appeared. They were all very gay, but not one of them had yet exceeded the bounds of reason. A hurrah of joy welcomed the general. 'Here I am,' said D'Artagnan, 'the campaign is ended.'

I am come to bring each his supplement of pay, as agreed upon.' Their eyes sparkled. 'I will lay a wager there are not, at this moment, a hundred crowns remaining in the purse of the richest among you.'

'That is true!' cried they in chorus.

'Gentlemen,' said D'Artagnan, 'then, this is the last order. The treaty of commerce has been concluded, thanks to our coup-de-main which made us masters of the most skilful financier of England, for now I am at liberty to confess to you that the man we had to carry off was the treasurer of General Monk.'

This word treasurer produced a certain effect on his army. D'Artagnan observed that the eyes of Menneville alone did not evince perfect faith. 'This treasurer,' he continued, 'I conveyed to a neutral territory, Holland; I forced him to sign the treaty; I have even reconducted him to Newcastle, and he was obliged to be satisfied with our proceedings towards him—the deal coffer being always carried without jolting, and being lined softly, I asked a gratification for you. Here it is.' He threw a respectable-looking purse upon the cloth; and all involuntarily stretched out their hands. 'One moment, my lambs,' said D'Artagnan; 'if there are profits, there are also charges.'

'Oh! oh!' murmured they.

'We are about to find ourselves, my friends, in a position which would not be tenable for people without brains. I speak plainly; we are between the gallows and the Bastille.'

'Oh! Oh!' said the chorus.

'That is easily understood. It was necessary to explain to General Monk the disappearance of his treasurer. I waited, for that purpose, till the unhoped-for moment of the restoration of King Charles II, who is one of my friends.'

This army exchanged a glance of satisfaction in reply to the sufficiently proud look of D'Artagnan. 'The king being restored, I restored to Monk his man of business, a little plucked, it is true, but, in short, I restored him. Now, General Monk, when he pardoned me, for he has pardoned me, could not help repeating these words to me, which I charge every one of you to engrave deeply there, between the eyes, under the vault of the cranium:—"Monsieur, the joke has been a good one, but I don't naturally like jokes; if ever a word of what you have done" (you understand me, Menneville) "escapes from your lips, or the lips of your companions, I have, in my government of Scotland and

Chapter XXXVII

How D'Artagnan regulated the 'Assets' of the Company



DECIDEDLY,' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'I have struck a good vein. That star which shines once in the life of every man, which shone for Job and Iris, the most unfortunate of the Jews and the poorest of the Greeks, is come at last to shine on me. I will commit no folly, I will take advantage of it; it comes quite late enough to find me reasonable.'

He supped that evening, in very good humour, with his friend Athos; he said nothing to him about the expected donation, but he could not forbear questioning his friend, while eating, about country produce, sowing, and planting. Athos replied complacently, as he always did. His idea was that D'Artagnan wished to become a land-owner, only he could not help regretting, more than once, the absence of the lively humour and amusing sallies of the cheerful companion of former days. In fact, D'Artagnan was so absorbed, that, with his knife, he took advantage of the grease left at the bottom of his plate, to trace ciphers and make additions of surprising roundity.

The order, or rather license, for their embarkation, arrived at Athos's lodgings that evening. While this paper was remitted to the comte, another messenger brought to D'Artagnan a little bundle of parchments, adorned with all the seals employed in setting off property deeds in England. Athos surprised him turning over the leaves of these different acts which established the transmission of property. The prudent Monk—others would say the generous Monk—had commuted the donation into a sale, and acknowledged the receipt of the sum of fifteen thousand crowns as the price of the property ceded. The messenger

Monk knitted his brow.—‘Glory, honour, probity!’ said he, ‘you are but empty words.’

‘Mist!’ replied D’Artagnan; ‘nothing but mist, through which nobody can see clearly.’

‘Well, then, go to France, my dear Monsieur d’Artagnan,’ said Monk; ‘go, and to render England more attractive and agreeable to you, accept a remembrance of me.’

‘What now?’ thought D’Artagnan.

‘I have on the banks of the Clyde,’ continued Monk, ‘a little house in a grove, cottage as it is called here. To this house are attached a hundred acres of land. Accept it as a souvenir.’

‘Oh, my lord!—’

‘Faith! you will be there in your own home, and that will be the place of refuge you spoke of just now.’

‘For me to be obliged to your lordship to such an extent! Really, your grace, I am ashamed.’

‘Not at all, not at all, monsieur,’ replied Monk, with an arch smile; ‘it is I who shall be obliged to you. And,’ pressing the hand of the musketeer, ‘I shall go and draw up the deed of gift,’—and he left the room.

D’Artagnan looked at him as he went out with something of a pensive and even an agitated air.

‘After all,’ said he, ‘he is a brave man. It is only a sad reflection that it is from fear of me, and not affection that he acts thus. Well, I shall endeavour that affection may follow.’ Then, after an instant’s deeper reflection,—‘Bah!’ said he, ‘to what purpose? He is an Englishman.’ And he in turn went out, a little confused after the combat.

‘So,’ said he, ‘I am a land-owner! But how the devil am I to share the cottage with Planchet? Unless I give him the land, and I take the château, or the he takes the house and I—nonsense! M. Monk will never allow me to share a house he has inhabited, with a grocer. He is too proud for that. Besides, why should I say anything about it to him? It was not with the money of the company I have acquired that property, it was with my mother-wit alone; it is all mine, then. So, now I will go and find Athos.’ And he directed his steps towards the dwelling of the Comte de la Fère.

Ireland, seven hundred and forty-one wooden gibbets, of strong oak, clamped with iron, and freshly greased every week. I will make a present of one of these gibbets to each of you, and observe well, M. d’Artagnan,” added he (observe it also, M. Menneville), “I shall still have seven hundred and thirty left for my private pleasure. And still further—”

‘Ah! ah!’ said the auxiliaries, ‘is there still more?’

‘A mere trifle. “Monsieur d’Artagnan, I send to the king of France the treaty in question, with a request that he will cast into the Bastille provisionally, and then send to me, all who have taken part in this expedition; and that is a prayer with which the king will certainly comply.”’

A cry of terror broke from all corners of the table.

‘There! there!’ said D’Artagnan, ‘this brave M. Monk has forgotten one thing, and that is he does not know the name of any one of you; I alone know you, and it is not I, you well may believe, who will betray you. Why should I? As for you—I cannot suppose you will be silly enough to denounce yourselves, for then the king, to spare himself the expense of feeding and lodging you, will send you off to Scotland, where the seven hundred and forty-one gibbets are to be found. That is all, messieurs; I have not another word to add to what I have had the honour to tell you. I am sure you have understood me perfectly well, have you not, M. Menneville?’

‘Perfectly,’ replied the latter.

‘Now the crowns!’ said D’Artagnan. ‘Shut the doors,’ he cried, and opened the bag upon the table, from which rolled several fine gold crowns. Every one made a movement towards the floor.

‘Gently!’ cried D’Artagnan. ‘Let no one stoop, and then I shall not be out in my reckoning.’ He found it all right, gave fifty of those splendid crowns to each man, and received as many benedictions as he bestowed pieces. ‘Now,’ said he, ‘if it were possible for you to reform a little, if you could become good and honest citizens—’

‘That is rather difficult,’ said one of the troop.

‘What then, captain?’ said another.

‘Because I might be able to find you again, and, who knows what other good fortune?’ He made a sign to Menneville, who listened to all he said with a composed air. ‘Menneville,’ said he, ‘come with me. Adieu, my brave fellows! I need not warn you to be discreet.’

Menneville followed him, whilst the salutations of the auxiliaries were mingled with the sweet sound of the money clinking in their pockets.

'Menneville,' said D'Artagnan, when they were once in the street, 'you were not my dupe; beware of being so. You did not appear to have any fear of the gibbets of Monk, or the Bastille of his majesty, King Louis XIV, but you will do me the favour of being afraid of me. Then listen; at the smallest word that shall escape you, I will kill you as I would a fowl. I have absolution from our holy father, the pope, in my pocket.'

'I assure you I know absolutely nothing, my dear M. d'Artagnan, and that your words have all been to me so many articles of faith.'

'I was quite sure you were an intelligent fellow,' said the musketeer; 'I have tried you for a length of time. These fifty crowns which I give you above the rest will prove the esteem I have for you. Take them.'

'Thanks, Monsieur d'Artagnan,' said Menneville.

'With that sum you can really become an honest man,' replied D'Artagnan, in the most serious tone possible. 'It would be disgraceful for a mind like yours, and a name you no longer dare to bear, to sink forever under the rust of an evil life. Become a gallant man, Menneville, and live for a year upon those hundred gold crowns: it is a good provision; twice the pay of a high officer. In a year come to me, and, *Mordieu!* I will make something of you.'

Menneville swore, as his comrades had sworn, that he would be as silent as the grave. And yet some one must have spoken; and as, certainly, it was not one of the nine companions, and quite as certainly, it was not Menneville, it must have been D'Artagnan, who, in his quality of a Gascon, had his tongue very near to his lips. For, in short, if it were not he, who could it be? And how can it be explained that the secret of the deal coffer pierced with holes should come to our knowledge, and in so complete a fashion that we have, as has been seen, related the history of it in all its most minute details; details which, besides, throw a light as new as unexpected upon all that portion of the history of England which has been left, up to the present day, completely in darkness by the historian of our neighbours?

'Yes, I understand, that would be unbearable; that is why, my lord, I came to say,—do you not think it would be better for me to set out for France as soon as possible?'

'Certainly, if you think your presence—'

'Would impose silence upon those scoundrels? Oh! I am sure of that, my lord.'

'Your presence will not prevent the report from spreading, if the tale has already transpired.'

'Oh! it has not transpired, my lord, I will wager. At all events, be assured that I am determined upon one thing.'

'What is that?'

'To blow out the brains of the first who shall have propagated that report, and of the first who has heard it. After which I shall return to England to seek an asylum, and perhaps employment with your grace.'

'Oh, come back! come back!'

'Unfortunately, my lord, I am acquainted with nobody here but your grace, and if I should no longer find you, or if you should have forgotten me in your greatness?'

'Listen to me, Monsieur d'Artagnan,' replied Monk; 'you are a superior man, full of intelligence and courage; you deserve all the good fortune this world can bring you; come with me into Scotland, and, I swear to you, I shall arrange for you a fate which all may envy.'

'Oh! my lord, that is impossible. At present I have a sacred duty to perform; I have to watch over your glory, I have to prevent a low jester from tarnishing in the eyes of our contemporaries—who knows? in the eyes of posterity—the splendour of your name.'

'Of posterity, Monsieur d'Artagnan?'

'Doubtless. It is necessary, as regards posterity, that all the details of that history should remain a mystery; for, admit that this unfortunate history of the deal box should spread, and it should be asserted that you had not re-established the king loyally, and of your own free will, but in consequence of a compromise entered into at Scheveningen between you two. It would be vain for me to declare how the thing came about, for though I know I should not be believed, it would be said that I had received my part of the cake, and was eating it.'

Monk was quite out of countenance at the idea of seeing himself represented in this box. Ridicule, as D'Artagnan had judiciously foreseen, acted upon him in a manner which neither the chances of war, the aspirations of ambition, nor the fear of death had been able to do.

'Good,' thought the Gascon, 'he is frightened: I am safe.'

'Oh! as to the king,' said Monk, 'fear nothing, my dear Monsieur d'Artagnan; the king will not jest with Monk, I assure you!'

The momentary flash of his eye was noticed by D'Artagnan. Monk lowered his tone immediately: 'The king,' continued he, 'is of too noble a nature, the king's heart is too high to allow him to wish ill to those who do him good.'

'Oh! certainly,' cried D'Artagnan. 'I am entirely of your grace's opinion with regard to his heart, but not as to his head—it is good, but it is trifling.'

'The king will not trifle with Monk, be assured.'

'Then you are quite at ease, my lord?'

'On that side, at least! yes, perfectly!'

'Oh! I understand you; you are at ease as far as the king is concerned?'

'I have told you I was.'

'But you are not so much so on my account?'

'I thought I had told you that I had faith in your loyalty and discretion.'

'No doubt, no doubt, but you must remember one thing—'

'What is that?'

'That I was not alone, that I had companions; and what companions!'

'Oh! yes, I know them.'

'And, unfortunately, my lord, they know you, too!'

'Well?'

'Well; they are yonder, at Boulogne, waiting for me.'

'And you fear—'

'Yes, I fear that in my absence—*Parbleu!* If I were near them, I could answer for their silence.'

'Was I not right in saying that the danger, if there was any danger, would not come from his majesty, however disposed he may be to jest, but from your companions, as you say? To be laughed at by a king may be tolerable, but by the horse-boys and scamps of the army! Damn it!'

'The circumstances of that abduction.'

'What circumstances?'

'Oh! you know very well what I mean, my lord.'

'No, curse me if I do.'

'There is—in truth, it is difficult to speak it.'

'There is?'

'Well, there is that devil of a box!'

Monk coloured visibly. 'Well, I have forgotten it.'

'Deal box,' continued D'Artagnan, 'with holes for the nose and mouth. In truth, my lord, all the rest was well; but the box, the box! that was really a coarse joke.' Monk fidgeted about in his chair. 'And, notwithstanding my having done that,' resumed D'Artagnan, 'I, a soldier of fortune, it was quite simple, because by the side of that action, a little inconsiderate I admit, which I committed, but which the gravity of the case may excuse, I am circumspect and reserved.'

'Oh!' said Monk, 'believe me, I know you well, Monsieur d'Artagnan, and I appreciate you.'

D'Artagnan never took his eyes off Monk; studying all which passed in the mind of the general, as he prosecuted his idea. 'But it does not concern me,' resumed he.

'Well, then, who does it concern?' said Monk, who began to grow a little impatient.

'It relates to the king, who will never restrain his tongue.'

'Well, and suppose he should say all he knows?' said Monk, with a degree of hesitation.

'My lord,' replied D'Artagnan, 'do not dissemble, I implore you, with a man who speaks so frankly as I do. You have a right to feel your susceptibility excited, however benignant it may be. What, the devil! it is not the place for a man like you, a man who plays with crowns and sceptres as a Bohemian plays with his balls; it is not the place of a serious man, I said, to be shut up in a box like some freak of natural history; for you must understand it would make all your enemies ready to burst with laughter, and you are so great, so noble, so generous, that you must have many enemies. This secret is enough to set half the human race laughing, if you were represented in that box. It is not decent to have the second personage in the kingdom laughed at.'